

The environmental and economical impact of "AI"

Posted by u/CuteCreatorgal • 0 points • 60 comments

[**How AI is causing people to abandon neighbourhoods**]

(<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=DIPMSDXNsV8>)

[**Environmental impact of AI Data Centres**](<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=t-8TDOFqkQA>)

Above are links to informative journalistic documentaries into how Data Centers and have been destroying people's lives/communities and resulting them having to abandon their neighbourhoods, as well as the economical and environmental impact of these data centres (Which "AI" relies on to function)*

I often see arguments centered around surface level issues, which often cover unethical data scraping, rendering artists "obsolete", and replacing human employment with automation.

Although these discussions are important, I believe a lot of people who are obsessively Pro "AI" have trouble with empathy toward their fellow humans, and have a "Keep up or perish" mindset, which at a fundamental level is anti-social and does not help keep a society healthy. Helping people to understand that "AI" affects everybody negatively (including themselves) may help some people view the bloated tech from a different perspective.

The most pressing problems that "AI" imposes on us, are the data centers that have been/are continuing to be built. [**These centers have been directly increasing your electricity and water bills**](<https://www.bloomberg.com/graphics/2025-ai-data-centers-electricity-prices/>), with electricity prices rising rapidly, recently [**outpacing inflation**] (<https://www.eia.gov/todayinenergy/detail.php?id=63064>). *How does this happen?* [Tech giants have been placing bids on annual power grid auctions to secure capacity for their data centers](<https://www.csis.org/analysis/electricity-supply-bottleneck-us-ai-dominance>), which means you get to pay for the increased prices as they are competing directly with you for land and water and energy supply.

For those of you who DO care about other humans, here is how it affects their neighbourhoods and environment; After the construction of data centers, residential neighborhoods situated nearby are being directly impacted. These residents have no say

over the construction or location, and they plan to pop up incrementally. Residents have documented resorting to relying on ear plugs to sleep at night due to severe noise & light pollution, [water supply contamination into households, low water pressure (almost zero water coming into households) resulting in people abandoning neighbourhoods] (<https://www.instagram.com/reel/DMfpOGLutse/?igsh=MnBqajU1MXBtMXdq>). (*This is also documented in the linked documentaries above.)*

\^ There is no definitive public directory of data centers, no official map, no single regulator to ask or government agency to foil. This means that it's currently almost impossible to get records because these companies don't want to disclose all of their information.

****Drought Issues;**** In places of drought and water stress such as Phoenix and Arizona, the situation is concerning. Some centers are drilling into the ground to use groundwater. Other centers are drawing most of their water from the Colorado River. The high water demand is intensifying the water crisis in the American Southwest, which is facing one of its worst droughts in over a millennium.

\^ The Colorado River makes its way south from the Rocky Mountains. It's precious water is siphoned off for agriculture industry and housing. Since 2000, river flow has shrunk by 20% so by the time it reaches Arizona, every drop counts. [These maps show how extreme drought has gripped the state since 2000](<https://www.azwater.gov/drought/drought-status>)

\^ [*A federal report*](<https://escholarship.org/uc/item/32d6m0d1#page=50>) *estimated that in 2023, indirect water consumption footprint (from electricity use) of data centers in the United States was roughly 211 billion gallons. Given that 176 terawatt-hours (TWh) of electricity were consumed by data centers in 2023, the centers indirect water consumption can be estimated at 1.2 gallons per kWh on average nationally in 2023.*

****Tax breaks;**** Massive corporations are benefitting from various taxes in different states for their data centers. States are offering tax incentive programs to data centers, such as zero tax on building materials, machinery or equipment & Preferential rates on water/electricity.

[At least 10 states already lose more than \$100 million per year in tax revenue to data centers. Of the 32 states with tax incentives to data centers, 12 fail to disclose even aggregate revenue losses](<https://goodjobsfirst.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/04/Cloudy-with-a-Loss-of-Spending-Control-How-Data-Centers-Are-Endangering-State-Budgets.pdf>)

While these over bloated tech companies get massive tax breaks, your schools get cuts, your healthcare gets cuts, your social services gets cuts. Sen. Erin Maye Quade [****highlights this corruption****](<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xcfV-VV3rvw>) as Minnesota publishes a tax expenditure report showing how much money you *don't* collect because of tax exemptions — money that could be going to schools, nursing homes,

disability services, and more.

\^ "All politicians and corporations want to talk about are the benefits, while ignoring or downplaying the costs of development subsidies. Let the companies compete on quality and price, not on how much they can extract from taxpayers and distort economic development and land use." Greg LeRoy

I don't want to add on much more as this post is already large enough as it is, I hope the issues above help some of us understand the real threats surrounding "AI".

It's not you vs me, It's billionaire corporations vs the general population.

Comments

u/Slight_Antelope_4148 • 2 points • 2025-11-28 04:49 UTC

Starting off with a dismissal of my empathy (and in particular, not that of the the side that's notorious for death threats etc) isn't a good way to reach out. I'm sure the responses I get will be non-psychotic.

u/CuteCreatorgal • 1 points • 2025-11-28 04:56 UTC

If out of all the information of issues above, your only takeaway is;

"Perhaps mentioning that obsessive Pro-Ai people may be less empathetic to the unethical impact on people and the environment was too far. This may understandably result in some psychotic reactions"

\^ then my point has been proven.

u/Late_Doctor5817 • -1 points • 2025-11-28 03:22 UTC

Americans trying to make their shithole policies peddled by their shithole politicians bought by their shithole companies keeping their country from being anything other than a shithole everyone else's problem, Is not proof that Artificial **Intelligence**, Is bad.

u/CuteCreatorgal • 1 points • 2025-11-28 03:27 UTC

The implementation of this tech is controlled by money backed companies and corrupted governments. I have focused on the direct unethical impacts (surrounding) AI data centers because it's the truth, and it's all recorded.

Your comment reminds me when people say "Guns aren't bad!" in response to Gun violence in America. Obviously it's complicated, and it's important for people to be aware of the problems that surround these tools when they're not properly regulated.

u/Late_Doctor5817 • 1 points • 2025-11-28 03:43 UTC

The information Is entirely centered around the US, ignoring the massive AI industry that Is located in China, yet your core argument Is that AI Is enviromentally harmful, by

virtue of what however?

Is it a fundamental necessity for AI to be harmful to the environment, or is your horrible country just doing the usual who-gives-a-shit-about-anyone-but-myself-im-an-american bit? Also, I deny the premise that AI is like guns, as it is obviously in bad faith and loaded with the implication that it is built for the specific purpose of harming others. AI datacenters are not unethical, nor are they harmful, the policies and incentives that allow these companies to do whatever without consequences and do what they can to race ahead no matter the cost to the locals are unethical and harmful.

If I am the president of a country and I decide I want a shit ton of nuclear power, and tell the residents of some town to get the fuck out now or else, then pave over their whole lives and put a nuclear power plant on top, and the residents now hate Nuclear and peddle their hatred of it towards everyone else creating a movement against Nuclear based on the premise that Nuclear is harmful for its effects on towns like theirs, citing their example, **does not say anything about Nuclear Power or Nuclear Power plants themselves, just the idiotic government**.

u/Tyler_Zoro • 2 points • 2025-11-28 03:14 UTC

So I just decided to fact-check that first video since its monotonic narrator was hitting all the "I'm going to cast this as evil without any specifics," buttons. (BTW: not that it really matters, but is that an AI voiceover?)

Yeah, so about that story...

Background:

The Roppolo Subdivision in unincorporated Elk Grove Township (yeah, the midwest loves their catchy town names) was insolvent, had lost their ability to fund firefighting and the datacenter operators offered them just under a million dollars each for their homes in order to bail them out and fund their move to another location.

That's not exactly how the narrator put it...

Are any of your other sources better than that absolute crock of lies?

([source](https://www.journal-topics.com/articles/annexation-of-subdivision-approved-by-elk-grove-village-for-2-1-million-sq-ft-data-center/))

u/LyzIL • 3 points • 2025-11-28 03:07 UTC

This is about as good of a post I've seen from the anti-ai side, even though it relies on the belief that pro-ai people lack empathy, which is an awkward starting point.

Let's get the tax break part out of the way first. Whether we agree or disagree that companies should get tax breaks, it's a very common practice for companies across many industries. It's hard to feel like anything special is happening on tax breaks alone with AI companies, although tbh the Trump admin has been way more generous to them than I think anyone would have expected. I agree that the companies should not have cozied up to the gov in this way and find that aspect detestable, but not enough to change my mind on AI's overall benefits.

I don't think many (if anyone) on the pro-ai side would deny the environmental issues with AI use. But

there are a lot of different numbers being thrown around here, and the numbers DO matter, as almost everything humans do has environmental impact.

Let's say we concede that AI is increasing humanity's environmental detriment by 10% overall, compared to a non-AI world. That would be pretty bad.

But, part of the premise of pro-ai people is that AI will eventually help with a great many things. This is speculative, and so I think it's fair to be skeptical, but I do think the insane pace of what AI has been able to achieve in the last 3 years does account for some measure of optimism. The hope is that within the next few years, AI will be just as capable and improving of a technology as the industrial revolution or electricity or computers. Each of these 3 evolutions of our technology have so profoundly shaped modern life it is hard to imagine almost any of the technological advances after each them without it. Other comparable mega-inventions it might be compared to are the engine, vaccines, antibiotics, plastics, telephone, or internet. Again, each of which a good 75% of modern life couldn't b imagined without.

It was very hard to see for people of those times just how completely revolutionary each of these technologies were. Electricity was first used for lightbulbs, yes, but also for the electric chair and people were dying of accidental electrocution regularly. Lightbulbs were neat, of course, but not exactly revolutionary if that's the only thing electricity ended up being used for. It was the next 10, 100, 1000 inventions that relied on electricity that have completely changed our lives.

The industrial revolution was even rougher. There is a fair argument to be made that it never should have happened, considering just how awful and exploitative it was. The current resurgence of the term 'luddite' came from this era, where people broke the machines that were destroying their artisan jobs - skills and lifestyles that have now mostly been lost forever. The transition was god awful, but at the same time, it is incredibly hard to imagine how we would have almost any of the luxuries we have today (including abundant food from now much more fruitful agricultural practices, changing over from 80% of all humans being farmers to now less than 3%).

Now, should we accept a 10% increase in our environmental impact for this speculative chance at a better world? I'm willing to concede there is an argument for it. But for me personally, I'd be willing to drive less, take less flights, or cut out meat from my diet before stopping AI progress. I haven't fully crunched the numbers, but each one of those probably accounts for 10% or more of the environmental impact humans make. I think the fact that these considerations very rarely make it into the conversation of Anti-AI arguments go to show that it isn't really environmental concern at the core of the argument, but something else about AI that people want halted.

u/LyzIL • 2 points • 2025-11-28 03:07 UTC

Of course I don't want people to be without drinking water or to cause droughts. But its almost impossible to point to any technological advancement and not have some ethical concern.

What many people don't talk about is actually how overall ethical AI HAS been as a rollout compared to much other technology. The fact that AI companies provide the state-of-the-art models to anyone at reasonable prices, or even free, is a level of democratic access almost never seen before the 21st century. Only the rich got access to telephones, flight, cars, etc. for the first decade or so of their production.

The fact that every major AI company actually has dedicated ethical guardrails, and fairly stringent ones at that, without being absolutely required to by the government is almost shocking. Sure there's relatively harmless ones people talk about often like nsfw erotic roleplay or sexual

imagery, but there are much more serious violations that they have curbed right from the start: no instructions on how to make dangerous weapons or chemical reactions, tight guidelines on hate speech and going down rabbit holes of misinformation, and lots of other concerns. Its actually fascinating to read about all the countless things they test and build guardrails for (I do AI training work part-time, so I've dealt with 100s of hours of this stuff in the last 2 years).

They are not perfect, by any means, but compared to the absolutely horror-shows that most companies throughout most of history have been, its night and day. We forget that companies used to colonize and build company towns for labor, have next to no health or safety provisions, and would literally (I mean this in the physical, real way) murder union leaders and members. Not that companies should be able to get away with anything today, but in context of the last 100 years, AI has had a remarkably safe and democratic rollout. Does this mean I think they should be able to do anything they want environmentally? Hell no. But it just feels like the issue is very overblown for the potential good AI can provide. I want all companies to be more responsible environmentally.